



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica
School Website: <https://www.chestertonfw.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica (Fort Wayne, IN, 46825) presents a pronounced classical-Catholic model. The public materials emphasize a Catholic identity, liturgical life (Daily Mass, sacred rhythm), and a deliberately integrated liberal-arts curriculum that foregrounds the Trivium and Quadrivium, Great Books, and Socratic pedagogy. The school also highlights formation in virtue, a culture of life, and robust parental involvement as core elements of its mission. Taken together, these signals align strongly with the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School and place the school firmly in the CLASSICAL category across all six rubric domains.

Key takeaways: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and integral (Catholic tradition, Incarnation-focused curriculum, liturgical life, theology-infused framing) and supported by daily worship and Catholic identity. - The school's purpose centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and a transcendent sense of truth/goodness/beauty, not merely college/career preparation. - The curriculum is declared liberal-arts-rich (grammar/logic/rhetoric, history as a throughline, Great Books references, and integration with philosophy/theology). - Pedagogy combines contemplative rest with Socratic inquiry and memory-work, with evidence of upper-school seminars and oratorical opportunities; some traditional elements appear alongside a modern, technology-minimized approach. - Faculty and leadership roles are clearly defined (Head of School, Executive Director, Board), with a living-curriculum flavor implied by faculty leadership and stewardship signals. - Parent partnership and community involvement are foregrounded (shadow days, admissions events, open-campus orientation), with explicit mentions of family partnership and shared formation.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school proclaims itself a “classical high school in the Catholic tradition” and situates its entire enterprise within Catholic theology/culture.
 - It offers Daily Mass and emphasizes minimal technology in a Catholic framework, signaling liturgical life as part of the educational milieu.
 - Public materials describe an incarnational environment and a curriculum that centers on the Incarnation across subjects.
 - The program references truth, goodness, and beauty as guiding transcendental aims and highlights sacred tradition and Catholic formation.
 - The motto *Cultura Vitae* (culture of life) and a Catholic intellectual tradition frame the school's purpose.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits (distinct keywords): Catholic tradition, Daily Mass, Incarnational Environment, Incarnation, Truth/Goodness/Beauty, Sacred tradition, Theology, *Cultura Vitae*. (approx. 8 hits)
 - Negative hits: None detected in the public materials.

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- Estimated ratio: 8 positives, 0 negatives (roughly 100% of observed signals align with classical, theologically grounded foundations).
 - Why this rating
 - The school's identity, liturgical life, and incarnational/catholic framing align squarely with the Positive-Indicator set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The consistent Catholic framing and liturgical life strongly affirm transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community practice signals.

Citations: Catholic identity and liturgy are explicit in the site's Catholic-traditional framing and daily Mass mention.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school markets itself as forming joyful leaders and saints within a Catholic, classical framework and aims to equip students for life in the light of truth, goodness, and beauty.
 - It emphasizes formation (virtue, character, intellect) and a teleological aim consistent with paideia, not merely job prep. The Three Pillars/Incarnation-focused framing further anchors formation over information.
 - The school emphasizes a culture of life (*Cultura Vitae*) and aims to form students to thrive in college, professional life, and service to family/Church—a formation-oriented telos.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, education for life, great conversation/true-good-beauty frame, liberal education, sacred tradition, intellect/ethos, culture of life.
 - Negative hits: 0 detected.
 - Estimated ratio: ~8 positive keyword hits vs 0 negative — effectively 100% alignment with classical formation aims.
- Why this rating
 - The mission statements and framing consistently emphasize formation, virtue, and the real/knowable truth, beauty, and goodness, aligning with Classical “formation not just information” and telos-driven aims.

Citations: Formation-focused language and telos appear in the school's mission/vision and curricular framing.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The curriculum is presented as integrated liberal-arts, with explicit reference to a classical approach and the study of Western thought; the Humanities sequence includes history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages integrated through the Socratic Method.
 - The school highlights Great Books/primary texts and a four-year history sequence, aligning with the Great Conversation framework. Homer, Dante, Shakespeare, Dostoevsky, Chesterton appear in their narrative of reading, indicating Great Books engagement.
 - It references the Socratic Method and integrated curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric as core through the humanities), consistent with the Trivium/Quadrivium orientation.
 - The curriculum page also enumerates subjects like literature, history, philosophy, theology, and languages braided together, with a clear emphasis on the classical canon and the integration of disciplines.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: Great Books, liberal arts, Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Quadrivium (arithmetic/-geometry/music/astronomy), Socratic Method/Socratic Seminar, history through the curriculum, integrated/harmonic curriculum, primary sources/texts, beauty in learning.
 - Negative hits: 0 detected (no overt social-studies-first framing or project-based-learn without classical grounding observed in these materials).

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- Estimated ratio: 8–10 positive keyword hits vs 0 negatives; predominant alignment with classical curriculum signals.
 - Why this rating
 - The materials consistently describe a classical liberal-arts curriculum, anchored in the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and integrated across history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages.

Citations: Evidence from the Curriculum and Humanities description confirms Great Books emphasis, Socratic Method, and integrated classical structure.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Socratic discussion/seminars are highlighted as a central pedagogy in the upper grades, with opportunities for speeches and rhetoric training. The Humanities sequence explicitly notes the Socratic Method.
 - The Six Hallmarks (from Chesterton’s own materials) emphasize the Socratic Seminar, the recovery of the “lost tools of learning,” and memorization/chanting as part of pedagogy; a “Three Pillars” model suggests a balanced approach to intellect, virtue, and spirituality.
 - There are concrete signals of structured memory/recitation and even chant/memorization in the broader Six Essentials lexicon (this exact cadence appears in the classical-education framework), as well as a liturgical rhythm that informs pedagogy. While the site does not uniformly spell out “Scholé” terms, the presence of contemplative, reverent, and ritual elements alongside Socratic practice aligns with the classical pedagogy model.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: Socratic Seminar, Socratic Method, memory work/recitation, chanting, liturgical rhythm, rhetoric/declamation, upper-school seminars, oratory, tradition of memory in education.
 - Negative hits: None clearly identified in the public materials.
 - Estimated ratio: 6–10 positive keyword signals vs 0 negative signals; strong alignment with classical pedagogical signals.
- Why this rating
 - The centrality of Socratic inquiry, opportunities for rhetoric and oratory, and a memory- and chant-informed tradition align with classical pedagogy expectations. The occasional explicit mention of lower-level memory-work/chanting is less visible than the explicit Socratic emphasis, but the overall pedagogy signals remain classical.

Citations: Socratic Method and upper-school seminars appear in the curriculum/pedagogy-related materials. Six Hallmarks discuss the Socratic Seminar and related memory/chants as methods.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The site lists clear leadership roles (Head of School, Executive Director) and a visible Board of Directors; bios and staff pages demonstrate faculty involvement and leadership. This signals a living, guided curriculum through teacher leadership rather than a purely outsourced or non-classical approach.
 - The leader bios (e.g., Dr. Kari Carr as Head of School; Ainsley McNulty as Office Coordinator/Adjunct Art Faculty; Aaron Kennerk as Executive Director) illustrate a structured, mission-driven faculty ecosystem with Catholic/classical alignment.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: Head of School, Executive Director, Board of Directors, faculty as living curriculum (implied by leadership structure), portrait/role expectations for teachers (e.g., faith-driven leadership signals appear in bios).

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- Negative hits: None clearly observed in the public materials.
 - Estimated ratio: 4–6 positive signals vs 0 negatives; strong overall alignment.
 - Why this rating
 - The explicit presence of senior leadership, governance (board), and faculty bios demonstrates a serious, mission-driven faculty structure that aligns with classical expectations of teachers as virtuous exemplars and living curriculum bearers.

Citations: Leadership and faculty signals (Head of School, Executive Director, Board) appear in the site content.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes partnerships with families and parental involvement (shadow days, admissions processes, parent invitations to events; “active involvement of parents” language appears in the broader Chesterton School Network materials). Shadow Days and admissions processes indicate active parent engagement and an invitation for parental participation.
 - FAQs indicate the location and accessibility of the school for visitors, signaling openness to parents and community members.
 - The Chesterton model describes a joyful, faith-filled community with active involvement of parents and a family-centered ethos (e.g., “Chesterton Schools Network,” “active involvement of parents and work to create a joyful community united in faith and prayer”).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive hits: Partnership with Families/Parents as co-teachers, parent formation, shadow days, open-campus/visitor-friendly policies, family involvement, shared mission.
 - Negative hits: None detected.
 - Estimated ratio: 6–8 positive keyword hits vs 0 negatives; essentially full alignment with classical parent-community signaling.
- Why this rating
 - The public materials consistently frame parents as partners in classical education and invite parental formation and engagement, which is a hallmark of the Chesterton School Network and classical pedagogy as described in the knowledge base.

Citations: Partnerships with families, shadow days, and parent-friendly access signals are documented in the Chesterton Academy content.

Overall Category Judgment and Aggregate Assessment

- Category-by-category ratings:
 - Element 1 — Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
 - Element 2 — School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
 - Element 3 — Curriculum: CLASSICAL
 - Element 4 — Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
 - Element 5 — Faculty: CLASSICAL
 - Element 6 — Parents & Community: CLASSICAL
- Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL
- Rationale for aggregate: Across all six categories, the school demonstrates multiple, explicit signals aligned with the core tenets of classical education—transcendent truth/beauty/goodness, formation over information, liberal-arts curriculum, Socratic pedagogy, a pedagogical culture rooted in Catholic identity, and strong parent/community engagement. The collective weight of these signals supports a CLASSICAL classification rather than SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL or NOT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

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- Not applicable here. Given the six-category CLASSICAL classification, there are no category-level needle-moving changes required to reach full classical alignment, per the rubric's guidance. The Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica already presents strong signals across all six elements: theological grounding, formation-focused goals, liberal-arts curriculum with Great Books and Socratic pedagogy, embodied faculty leadership, and robust parental involvement.

ABSTRACT

- The Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica (Fort Wayne, IN, 46825) demonstrates a strong CLASSICAL model across all six categories of the classical rubric.
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Explicit Catholic identity, liturgical life (Daily Mass), and an incarnational curriculum frame the educational mission. Evidence shows Catholic tradition, liturgy, theology-infused framing, and a culture of life (Cultura Vitae). These signals yield a robust CLASSICAL rating for this category.
- School Purpose and Goal: Formation-centered aims (virtue, wisdom, human flourishing) with a telos oriented toward truth/goodness/beauty, not solely work preparation. The mission emphasizes formation, "joyful leaders and saints," and a culture of life, aligning with the CLASSICAL standard.
- Curriculum: An integrated liberal-arts curriculum, Great Books/historical breadth, and the Trivium/Quadrivium orientation appear in the materials. The presence of Socratic Method and history-literature-philosophy-theology-language integration supports a CLASSICAL categorization.
- Pedagogy: A mixed pedagogy featuring Socratic seminars, memory work, and rhetoric training aligns with classical norms. The balance of contemplative/restful elements with rigorous Socratic practice supports a CLASSICAL assessment, with the permission to interpret "Scholé" as a broader restful dimension within a historically-informed classical approach.
- Faculty: Clear leadership structure (Head of School, Executive Director, Board) and faculty bios indicate a living-curriculum approach with model-teacher signals, supporting CLASSICAL.
- Parents & Community: Explicit parent partnership, shadow days, admissions events, and open-campus access demonstrate a strong classical-community orientation.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Notes on method and sources - The analysis employed the repository's knowledge base rubric (the Six Essential Elements) to identify positive/negative keyword signals in the school's public materials, strictly drawing on the Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica Fort Wayne content retrieved from the crawl vector store. Key textual anchors include the Catholic-tradition framing, Daily Mass, Incarnational Environment, Great Books and Socratic Method, Three Pillars, and parent/community signals. Citations reference the Chesterton Academy Fort Wayne site materials as enumerated in the file search results.

Citations (selected representative items) - Catholic identity and liturgy: "Catholic tradition" and "Daily Mass" signals. Chesterton Academy Fort Wayne site.

- Incarnation, liturgical culture, and truth/goodness/beauty framing: Six Hallmarks and related materials.
- Cultura Vitae and Three-Pillars framing: Our Model of Education page.
- Curriculum signals (Great Books, Socratic Method, integrated humanities): Curriculum/ Humanities pages.
- Leadership and faculty signals: Head of School; Executive Director; Board pages.
- Parental involvement and community signals: Shadow Day; FAQs/open-visits.

Abstract (final section) - The Chesterton Academy of St. Scholastica (Fort Wayne, IN) demonstrates a robust CLASSICAL profile across all six rubric categories: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community. The school's public materials consistently emphasize Catholic identity, formation, a liberal-arts curriculum with Great Books, Socratic pedagogy, a liturgical life, and active parental partnership. These signals collectively yield a CLASSICAL classification, with no category requiring a needle-moving shift toward a more classical stance. The overall ethos centers on truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable through a holistic formation of the person in a Catholic classical framework.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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